Visibility Bias — 1-page summary

Measuring Visibility Bias in Bureaucratic Text: A Validated Instrument with Evidence from Chinese Municipal Government Work Reports

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One-paragraph summary

I introduce the **Visibility Attention Index (VAI)**, a validated text-based instrument for measuring *compositional policy attention* in bureaucratic documents, applied to **6,294 Chinese municipal government work reports** (282 prefectures, 2002—2024). The instrument operationalizes a cadre-attention model in which officials allocate rhetorical emphasis between *visible* (streetscapes, greening, façades) and *functional* (water, drainage, structural safety) urban-infrastructure categories under a principal with asymmetric observability. I subject the instrument to a **five-test construct-validity battery** including, as the key methodological innovation, a **within-document retrospective-vs-prospective differential** ($\Delta = +0.025$, paired $t = 8.4$, $p < 10^{-16}$) that exploits the temporal section structure of bureaucratic documents. Two applications demonstrate utility (compositional substitution in MOHURD accounting data: $\beta = +0.111$, $p = 0.002$; structural welfare calibration yielding ¥1—15B/year). Two pre-registered null results are reported transparently, including one that reverses when the sample is extended to heterogeneity-robust estimation.

Key contribution (methodological)

The **within-document behavioral signature** — showing that retrospective report sections are systematically more visibility-loaded than prospective sections, using the *same lexicon, same author, same report* — is, to my knowledge, novel in the text-as-data literature. It cannot be produced by lexicon-selection bias, author-style effects, or report-length artifacts. It is a diagnostic that any annual bureaucratic-report corpus (EU NRPs, Indian state budgets, Mexican municipal plans) could reproduce.

What I am asking for

I would value **substantive feedback** on: - Whether the construct-validity protocol meets your bar for a measurement instrument in this genre - Whether the domain-scope claim (governance-rhetoric, full stop) is defensible given the Wikipedia-null finding - Whether the within-document differential (E-B) is as novel in the text-methods literature as I believe it is

I am particularly interested in co-authorship on the measurement-focused paper if the construct-validity battery meets your standards. I am finalizing the manuscript and would welcome your engagement at whatever level works for your schedule (feedback only, co-author, or acknowledgment).

Key evidence in 5 figures

1. **E-A Dictionary robustness**: r(VAI_original_42terms, VAI_expanded_148terms) = 0.93 across 5,686 GWRs
2. **E-B Within-document signature**: review − plan $\Delta = +0.025$, paired $t = 8.4$, $p < 10^{-16}$ ($N = 4{,}330$)
3. **E-D Cross-source validation**: r(VAI, MOHURD yearbook CIR) = 0.24, $p < 10^{-30}$
4. **E-F Wikipedia null (scope boundary)**: r(VAI, Wiki-derived VAI) = −0.15, 95% CI [−0.31, +0.02]; interpretation: governance-rhetoric vs encyclopedic-description domain mismatch
5. **P1 Accounting-data application**: CIR = β · VAI + controls + FE, $\beta = +0.111$, $p = 0.002$ across 2,751 city-years

Pre–registration discipline

All five construct–validity tests pre–registered before execution. Five deviations from pre–registration are logged in Appendix D with reasons, executed substitutes, and effect–on–sign/significance. Two results — H2 inspection event study (failed under heterogeneity–robust extension) and H5 CFPS amenity test (not executable as pre–registered, substitute returned null) — are reported transparently.

What is NOT claimed

This is explicitly not a causal–identification paper. The event–study approach to anti–corruption inspection shock *does not* survive heterogeneity–robust estimation when the window is extended to 2017. I report this prominently rather than bury it.

Full manuscript (~9,500 words) and replication archive available upon request.